

Look, watch, hear, and listen

Learner workbook

Describe attention and perception.

Understand the distinction

Look at directs visual attention toward something. Watch usually involves attention over time, often to something changing or moving. Hear describes receiving sound; listen emphasizes paying attention to it.

Use to before the object of listen: listen to music. Hear does not need to before its object. The attention distinction is useful but not absolute: hear a speaker can also mean attend a talk. Learn familiar activity phrases such as watch television and look at a photo.

Compare the patterns

DIRECT ATTENTION

Look at this photo.

Turn your attention to it.

OVER TIME

We watched the match.

Follow an event as it develops.

SOUND

I heard music and stopped to listen to it.

The sound was perceived, then attended to.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete: Please listen ___ the announcement.

A. at

B. to

C. for to

2. Choose the verb for viewing the game as it happened: We ___ the game.

A. watched

B. listened

C. looked

3. Choose the correction: I heard to a loud noise.

A. I listened a loud noise.

B. I heard at a loud noise.

C. I heard a loud noise.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. You first noticed a voice, then paid attention to an announcement. Which pair fits?

- A. I heard a voice outside. I listened the announcement.
- B. I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.
- C. I heard to a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. B. to

Listen takes to before the object.

2. A. watched

Watch is natural for following a game.

3. C. I heard a loud noise.

Hear takes the object directly.

4. B. I heard a voice outside. I listened to the announcement.

Heard describes noticing sound; listened to describes deliberate attention.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-39.html